

The Psychedelic Experience as a Sublime Aesthetic

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Abstract

The psychedelic experience has long been neglected by philosophical discourse. In this dissertation, I examine the psychedelic experience within the philosophy of art, arguing that this experience evokes a sublime aesthetic. By presenting the lineage of the sublime, I emphasize Burke and Kant's respective formulation of the concept. I establish the important features of both theories, highlighting their similarities and differences. Subsequently, I survey scientific research and subjective reports of psychedelic experiences to note their key aspects, both neurological and empirical. By particularly examining the mechanism of ego death, I note the therapeutic benefits of psychedelic-assisted therapy. This informs the final chapter of the dissertation, where I first examine two works that create a connection between psychedelics and the sublime. These accounts, however, are underdeveloped, creating a need for a stronger framework that can more wholly understand the psychedelic experience. To respond to this need, I show that Burke's conception of the sublime can serve as this framework, as it aligns with the psychedelic experience's emotional duality of awe and terror, along with the sense of self-preservation that arises through ego death. This understanding fits the psychedelic experience far better than Kant's sublime, and, by making this connection, I establish the importance of an aesthetic investigation as a complement to scientific knowledge. This dissertation opens many doors to future investigations of the psychedelic experience, both in an aesthetic sense and beyond.

Introduction

This dissertation argues that psychedelic experiences evoke a sublime aesthetic. I argue this by first presenting the historical trajectory of the sublime, beginning with its 17th-century origins. I show that a new translation of Longinus's work shaped this discourse, all before presenting the ways in which Edmund Burke and, subsequently, Immanuel Kant deviated from this tradition. While Longinus understands the sublime as noble, powerful persuasion, Burke's theory is shown to add an emotional complexity by introducing terrifying components. Complimented by awe and marked by a feeling of self-preservation, this terror, though sublimated, critically shifts discourse on the sublime away from pure nobility. After discussing Burke, I show that this terror is not present in Kant's mathematical sublime, which is instead rooted in apprehensions of things grand in size. However, Kant's dynamical sublime highlights that terror has a place in the sublime, though it is not directly felt.

Chapter Two shifts to psychedelics, both defining them and providing an overview of their effects. I first define psychedelics by using clinical research to isolate the category of classical psychedelics. This grouping forms the basis of investigation for the rest of the chapter, where I highlight the potent neurological and subjective effects of psychedelics, including perceptual strangeness and a lack of understanding about one's environment. I go on to show that these effects are most extreme in the loss of a subjective sense of self, or ego death. I conclude the chapter by highlighting the long-term therapeutic benefits that often accompany psychedelic experiences, particularly emphasizing that such outcomes are typically attributed to the neurological correlates of ego death.

In the final chapter, I bring the separate threads of the sublime and psychedelics together to show that the psychedelic experience, in its most profound formulation, is a sublime aesthetic. To do this, I first approach two previous works that attempt to make a similar

connection. The first aims to connect the two in a literary sense, arguing that Aldous Huxley embodies a sublime aesthetic in his essay about his own psychedelic experience, particularly in a Burkean sense. However, I demonstrate that this connection is underdeveloped, as it lacks an evaluation of whether this balance truly does match the sublimated terror necessary for the Burkean sublime. The other work I explore is an attempt to understand both positive and negative psychedelic experiences through the lens of Kantian aesthetics. While it particularly highlights ways in which the psychedelic experience exhibits the mathematical sublime, it, like the previous work, falters by merely understanding challenging experiences as sublime without critically evaluating the aspect of fear.

After understanding where previous theories fail, I use the remaining part of the final chapter to revise them, presenting my own understanding of a psychedelic sublime aesthetic. Firstly, I show that the psychedelic experience, through mild terror arising from strangeness, greatly embodies a balanced, Burkean emotional duality that emanates themes of self-preservation. Then, I explore how the Kantian mathematical sublime is one of many reported effects of psychedelics, while the dynamical sublime can account for low-dose, non-intensive psychedelic experiences. Reiterating my goal of utilizing a framework of the sublime to understand the power of the psychedelic experience, I finally establish that Burke's conception is more apt to do so than Kant's. Particularly, I clarify that the Burkean sublime is a strong framework for understanding high-dose psychedelic experiences that are not thoroughly adverse. I then go on to address the value of an experiential, aesthetic conception of the psychedelic experience. I show that this perspective adds depth to the scientific side of psychedelics, providing new ways to understand their effects. All the while, I continue, a psychedelic understanding of the sublime shows the value of neuroscience when it comes to the discipline of aesthetics, not diluting but enhancing philosophical understandings.

Chapter One: The Sublime

As a term, the sublime refers to a variety of historical conceptions dating to antiquity. This introductory chapter serves to elucidate leading conceptions of the sublime. In so doing, I first conceptualize the concept in aesthetic discourse, particularly noting Longinus's treatise on the topic and its ensuing influence in modern aesthetics. Then, I examine Edmund Burke's introduction of terror into the sublime and the stark contrast he makes between the sublime and the beautiful. The final conception of the sublime that I analyze is from Immanuel Kant and features the key element of human rationality. Throughout presenting each sublime tradition, I trace the term's trajectory by exploring both the similarities and the differences between these texts.

The Roots of the Sublime

In exploring the sublime, it is easy to let our preconceptions of the term guide our understanding of its usage in a philosophical context. Holmqvist and Płuciennik (2002: 720) note that this creates a large problem, as the word sublime represents attributes like nobility and dignity, despite the term meaning far more in an aesthetic sense. But this noble definition finds its roots in Longinus's *On the Sublime*. This ancient Greek treatise, though written in the first century AD, ignited intellectual interest in the sublime when it was translated in 1674 by John Boileau (Holmqvist and Płuciennik, 2002: 719). This translation largely contributed to common understandings of the sublime, though it greatly deviated from Longinus's own vision (Holmqvist and Płuciennik, 2002: 719; Monk, 1962: 17). Many of these deviations arise from the fact that his treatise is not by nature a philosophical text—instead it focuses on literary techniques—but instead was given an aesthetic dimension centuries later (Monk, 1962: 10). It is through this treatise, though, that Longinus defined and invigorated discourse on the sublime

that had begun to form rapidly in the 17th century and continued long into the 18th century (Monk, 1962: 10).

At the root of his treatise, Longinus argues that the sublime involves literary or oratory persuasion of the audience “of the efficacy of an idea by means of sheer rhetorical force” (Shaw, 2008: 5). Through his focus on sublime rhetoric, he seeks to understand what is necessary to make a performance powerful and persuasive, believing that, for a work to be considered sublime, it is critical that it elicits a strong emotional response from the audience (Monk, 1962: 11). Longinus states, “That which is admirable ever confounds our judgement and eclipses that which is merely reasonable or agreeable” (Longinus, 1890: 2). Indeed, wonder and astonishment, or shock and awe, are powerful feelings that do more to an audience than pleasant words of persuasion, as they linger in the audience, unable to be forgotten. Rather than the methodical persuasion often seen in polite debate, the sublime “exhibits the whole power of the orator in a moment of time” (Longinus, 1890: 3). Essentially, to Longinus, sublime rhetoric is powerful and incredibly persuasive, though not in a conventional sense. However, by being rooted in persuasive rhetoric, the Longinian sublime fits the aforementioned characterization of innocent or naïve, emanating pure nobility without any nefarious element (Des Pres, 1983). In short, the Longinian sublime in rhetoric can be described as greatness, compared to lesser works of mere goodness. As such, upon Longinus’s translation in modernity, discourse around the sublime viewed the term as emblematic of a distinct, elevated state of appreciation that embodied greatness.

The Burkean Sublime

Edmund Burke’s *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* marks a strong departure from the Longinian tradition, which had remained dominant until his work. Des Pres (1983: 137) notes that this transition from Longinus to Burke in the

sublime tradition marks an irreversible shift from naivety in the sublime to a conception wholly lacking such innocence. Though Longinus (1890) presents harrowing sections of literature, like in Homer's *Illiad*, views these passages as sublime through a noble lens, not confronting the terror of the scene directly. Burke's sublime is quite the opposite, as his focus shifts to the terrifying aspects of aesthetic experience.

Burke notably created an aesthetic system that departed from prevailing tradition through its clear distinction between the beautiful and the sublime (Monk, 1962: 86). His work begins with an investigation of our preconceptions of pleasure and pain. Noting our typical understanding, which separates the two concepts as distinct antonyms, Burke (2004: 80) says,

I am rather inclined to imagine, that pain and pleasure in their most simple and natural manner of affecting, are each of a positive nature, and by no means necessarily dependent on each other for existence.

In this statement, Burke challenges us to imagine that the cessation of pleasure is not necessarily pain and vice versa; these two feelings are in a more complicated relationship. This distinction forms the foundation of Burke's exploration into aesthetics, which is specifically focused on aesthetic emotions (Quinton, 1961: 71). Burke emphasizes the value of experience in his work, and, as such, he "restricts his enquiry to that which can be verified by experience" (Shaw, 2008: 53). This focus, notably, looks away from the objects that produce the sublime and toward the emotions found in the viewer instead (Monk, 1962: 93). In essence, to Burke, the sublime is best examined as a feeling that is experienced.

Burke presents his understanding of the sublime early in his work:

Whatever is fitted in any sort to excite the ideas of pain, and danger, that is to say, whatever is in any sort terrible, or is conversant about terrible objects, or operates in a manner

analogous to terror, is a source of the *sublime*; that is, it is productive of the strongest emotion which the mind is capable of feeling (Burke, 2004: 86).

Here, he establishes a central element of pain, or danger, in the sublime. This is perhaps the most important contribution Burke gives to the sublime, as it creates an emotional duality in the aesthetic. The first half of this duality is terror, while the other is the positive feeling of awe engendered in the viewer, a combination which Burke (2004: 115) characterizes as “delightful horror.” However, the sublime balance between these emotions is delicate because, “[w]hen danger or pain press too nearly, they are incapable of giving any delight, and are simply terrible” (Burke, 2004: 86). Thus, the delight of the sublime is attributable to a pain that is subliminal, not imparting a legitimate fear for one’s own life. An example would be bungee jumping. As Shaw (2008: 54) states, “The bungee jump mimics the suicidal jump into the abyss, providing the person who falls with a glimpse of what that descent *might* really entail.” The bungee cord provides a sense of security, but it is the feeling of frightful freefall that seduces those who jump. Rather than pressing danger, the bungee jump represents fear felt at a distance and is compatible with pleasure. It is this delicate balance between awe and terror that will form the basis of my investigation of a psychedelic sublime in the final chapter.

As stated earlier in this section, a significant aspect of Burke’s *Enquiry* is that it creates a clear separation between the beautiful and the sublime. Beauty, to Burke, is a social feeling, and it is marked by “sentiments of tenderness and affection” (Burke, 2004: 89). He goes on to say that our relationship with beauty is a willing one, as we crave such affection and feelings of love through engaging in pleasing things. However, with the sublime, “astonishment is the state of the soul, in which all its motions are suspended, with some degree of horror” (Burke, 2004: 101). The beautiful has been established to be a willing relationship that we enter, but Burke suggests here that the sublime is something that, instead, enters us through no control of our own. By suspending our motions, there is an element of shock that strikes and consumes

the viewer. In short, the sublime is not found walking through a field of flowers with appreciation; it is instead found in sudden, forceful feelings of delightful horror.

The sublime, to Burke, importantly relies on feelings of self-preservation. As he puts it, “The passions which concern self-preservation, turn mostly on pain or danger” (Burke, 2004: 86). This link between the sublime and self-preservation recalls the example of bungee jumping. During a bungee jump, the jumper has the feeling that he is on the verge of death. This fear of catastrophe is so strongly presented to the jumper and causes the same sort of feelings during the freefall as would be present without the rope there. Costelloe (2012: 29) describes such a feeling as when the body and mind “are threatened with annihilation by outward objects but also because of the tendency from within to render mental functions inert.” Despite the terror of the bungee jump that elicits feelings of self-preservation, the rope is there, and, if it were not, it would not be a sublime experience. The rope’s presence balances the terror into delightful horror and reflects the idea that the Burkean sublime is a moment in which the mind is confronted with the possibility of demolition, all while being assured that it will remain intact (Des Pres, 1983: 138-139). This dynamic of self-preservation is powerful and will be employed in the final chapter to make sense of the subjective feelings evoked in the psychedelic experience.

While Burke spends much time exploring what can evoke the sublime, his investigation of the aesthetic is based on experience, and so the qualities he mentions do not *necessarily* evoke the sublime. As such, I will not explore these qualities. But what is important to emphasize is the significance of the sublime in Burke’s *Enquiry*. Namely, there is wide agreement that, “for Burke, the sublime is the strongest emotional response of which the human being is capable” (Costelloe, 2012: 29). It is not just a powerful emotional state but represents the deepest depth of human emotions. By bungee jumping, the jumper embraces the rare feeling of his full emotional power. In so doing, a cathartic effect takes hold of the body and the mind,

reanimating the vital forces after the encounter with terror (Costelloe, 2012: 29). Through this understanding of the sublime, which highlights both pleasure *and* pain, we are encouraged to rethink art, allowing us to view a greater range of work as pleasing (Monk, 1962: 91). Monk (1962: 90) mentions that gothic novels are an example of this idea because their pleasing terror typically does not fit the schema of purely enjoyable art. Burke helps us understand that the terrifying gothic elements of these works are a critical aspect of their appeal, allowing for greater appreciation. Ultimately, through Burke's clear delineation of the sublime, he creates a wholly new conception of the term that stands as a strong testament to the power of human emotionality.

The Kantian Sublime

Writing just a few decades after Burke, Kant presented his own understanding of the sublime in his *Critique of Judgement*. His approach begins in a similar way to Burke, as both Burke and Kant "built their aesthetic theories on the dualism of the beautiful and the sublime" (Holmqvist and Pluciennik, 2002: 719). Kant first establishes that beautiful objects seem purposive, or adapted to our ability to comprehend their beauty (Shaw, 2008: 78). This is displayed in a passage where Kant discusses the beauty of flowers: "Hardly any one but a botanist knows what sort of a thing a flower ought to be" (Kant, 2007: 60). Essentially, beauty is a free-flowing trait that can only be attributable to objects that exist with regard to no particular end, or purpose.

As opposed to beauty, Kant begins his discussion of the sublime by stating,

[T]he sublime is to be found in an object even devoid of form, so far as it immediately involves, or else by its presence provokes, a representation of *limitlessness*, yet with a super-added thought of its totality (Kant, 2007: 75).

Here, Kant exemplifies a distinct attribute of his theory by asserting that the sublime is engendered by formless objects with an infinite presence. Breaking this down, Kant is saying that formlessness is hard to comprehend; it frustrates our imagination (Guyer, 1997: 235; Shaw, 2008: 78). Beautiful things are digestible, as a flower does not necessitate mental work to comprehend or appreciate. On the other hand, an example of the sublime would be an infinite universe. Shaw (2008: 80) explores this idea by saying that his own ability to “conceive of an infinite universe at the very moment when my imagination fails points to the existence of a faculty completely unrelated to sensuous intuition.” Contemplating our universe seems to require our imagination, but we cannot use it to paint a mental picture of an *infinite* universe that we do not know the totality of. However, we still can readily conceive of our infinite universe. This, then, points to the idea that a faculty beyond imagination is utilized when thinking of infinite, or formless, objects.

At this point, we are left wondering what faculty allows us to conceive of infinite things, as well as why such thought is sublime. To the first quandary, Kant (2007: 76) says the following:

For the sublime, in the strict sense of the word...rather concerns ideas of reason, which, although no adequate presentation of them is possible, may be aroused and called to mind by that very inadequacy itself which does admit of sensuous presentation.

Essentially, to Kant, it is the faculty of reason that grants us the ability to conceive of formless, infinite things. We cannot completely imagine sublime-inducing objects in our minds, yet rational thinking allows us to understand and talk about them, like the concept of an infinite universe. Kant then says that this use of rationality is sublime because the sublime is “brought about by the feeling of a momentary check to the vital forces followed at once by a discharge all the more powerful” (Kant, 2007: 75-76). This, essentially, represents a frustrating overload

of the imagination and subsequent reliance on rationality, which is akin to the cathartic, Burkean release upon experiencing delightful horror. Guyer (1997: 235) further disentangles Kant: “the superiority of this faculty over our other higher faculties of cognition is the actual ground of our pleasure in sublimity.” To put it simply, rationality acts as a failsafe for cognition, allowing us to comprehend the object instigating the feeling of the sublime. Maybe not every aspect is understood, but we are able to readily talk and conceive of the object. In this triumph of reason, which makes the impressive potential of our rational mind apparent, comes the pleasure of the sublime, to Kant.

Kant goes on to describe two versions of the sublime. The first is the mathematical sublime, which “is a greatness comparable to itself alone” (Kant, 2007: 80). He further clarifies by saying that, relative to the viewer, the sublime is conveyed when our aesthetic estimation of size proves no comparable alternative (Kant, 2007: 82). In short, the mathematical sublime is related to size and scale, wherein the sublime aesthetic is conveyed through greatness in these characteristics. Costelloe (2012: 39) identifies this feeling of the mathematical sublime as being in the “sweet spot,” where the viewer is neither consumed by the size of the instigating object nor able to fully understand the scale of its size. Kant (2007: 83) utilizes St. Peter’s Basilica in Rome as an example, saying, “For here a feeling comes home to him of the inadequacy of his imagination for presenting the idea of a whole within which that imagination attains its maximum.” Fundamentally, at the Basilica, there is an inability to imagine the full size of the seemingly infinite intricacies of the artistic feat, causing frustration. However, to allow for contemplation of these objects, our faculty of reason causes delight in its higher ability to comprehend the seemingly incomprehensible. This experience of the infinite in the mathematical sublime will later be explored as a commonly reported effect of psychedelics.

The second form of the sublime Kant presents is the dynamical sublime, which is characterized as follows: “Nature considered in an aesthetic judgement as might that has no

dominion over us” (Kant, 2007: 90). It is the dynamical sublime that converges greatly with Burke’s understanding of the sublime, as Kant goes on to explain that an element of fear must be present in the dynamical sublime. Just like how Burke sees the necessity for this fear, or terror, to be at a distance, Kant’s sublime is also “a source of delight, in other words, because it is contemplated from afar” (Shaw, 2008: 82). But Kant goes further by emphasizing a lack of any felt fear in the dynamical sublime. Instead, the importance of fear in the dynamical sublime is rather found in the recognition that the object instantiating the sublime is capable of instilling fear (Kant, 2007: 91). Put simpler, central to the dynamical sublime is “our simply picturing to ourselves the case of our wishing to offer some resistance to [the inciting object], and recognizing that all such resistance would be quite futile” (Kant, 2007: 91). An example would be the Grand Canyon, where we are seemingly powerless against such a rock formation that has no regard for human life. To comprehend the scale of the Grand Canyon’s seemingly infinite might would not be a feat for our imagination. Rather, it is our rationality that allows us to grasp our position relative to its might. While we may think that the Grand Canyon is at the cusp of consuming us fully, our rationality allows us to enjoy the sight, rather than be paralyzed by a pressing terror. Thus, the dynamical sublime, like the mathematical sublime, highlights the power of human rationality, though in the context of comprehending the fear of a potential, but not pressing, threat. Like the mathematical sublime, this feeling of unfelt but recognized fear will be examined in the final chapter as a potential philosophical framework for the psychedelic experience.

Kant’s sublime, much like Burke’s, holds great importance. To Kant (2007: 94), “Sublimity, therefore, does not reside in any of the things of nature, but only in our own mind, in so far as we may become conscious of our superiority over nature.” In essence, by appealing to reason to understand the scale of the mathematical sublime or the might of the dynamical sublime, we recognize the elevated status of our own mind. Costelloe (2012: 40) furthers this

point by stating that the Kantian sublime, in demonstrating our full rational capacity, makes clear that self-preservation is not the ultimate goal of being; the use of our unique, human rationality, however, is. Ultimately, Kant's sublime then becomes an elevated and desirable state of aesthetic appreciation that reinforces a uniquely human value.

Overall, discourse over the sublime largely began with a modern translation of Longinus, who ascribed a nobility to rhetoric that elicited a powerful and persuasive emotional response from its audience. Burke dramatically shifted the concept, instilling terror as a central aspect of the sublime. This Burkean sublime represents a fight for self-preservation, albeit one that assures the security of the viewer. Kant, however, restructured this conception of the sublime. On the one hand is a mathematical sublime, which delights in ideas of grandiose size. The other sublime, the dynamical sublime, is akin to the Burkean sublime in that there is an aspect of terror, yet such terror is not felt but instead merely acknowledged as a potentiality in the Kantian formulation. Central to both variations of Kant's sublime is that rationality is utilized when imagination cannot comprehend the object inciting the sublime. All of these understandings of the sublime represent centuries of inquiry and are still relevant today, marking an elevated state of aesthetic experience.

Chapter Two: The Psychedelic Experience

This second chapter serves as an overview of psychedelics. I begin this exploration by defining psychedelics, specifically focusing on classical, serotonergic psychedelics. Then, I show how these drugs operate on the mind and the body. Throughout, I utilize various subjective reports and several scientific papers on psychedelics that demonstrate their neurological and experiential effects. Before concluding, I briefly examine the potential therapeutic benefits of psychedelics and the origins of these positive effects.

Defining Psychedelics

It is important to note that there is no singular definition of the class of drugs typically termed “psychedelics.” The term psychedelic was created through correspondence between the writer Aldous Huxley and the psychedelic researcher Humphrey Osmond in 1956 (Pollan, 2018: 162). The chosen word, psychedelic, came from a couplet by Osmond: “To fall in hell or soar Angelic / You’ll need a pinch of psychedelic” (Pollan, 2018: 163). Arising from this simple couplet, the term has undeniably become a broad one in popular culture, referring to a wide range of substances. However, there has come to be a distinction between classical psychedelics and psychedelic-adjacent substances to avoid confusion. As first elucidated by Griffiths (2006: 269), the classical psychedelics are psilocybin, LSD, mescaline, and DMT, all of which are categorized together because of their similarities in effects. While this categorization is generally accepted, others still employ “psychedelics” when referring to drugs such as MDMA, or even cannabis, highlighting these drugs’ psychoactive natures (Pollan, 2018: 37). However, the delineation of classical psychedelics and their close similarities in effects represents a distinguished classification of drugs, and I will invoke this grouping throughout the rest of this dissertation when using the term psychedelics.

Neurological and Subjective Effects

The similarities between the classical psychedelics are due to the fact “that psychedelics like LSD and psilocybin work on the human brain by binding with the 5-HT_{2A} [serotonin] receptors” (Pollan, 2018: 240). These drugs fit snugly into the 5-HT_{2A} receptors—in the case of LSD, far better than serotonin itself—marking the roots of their effects (Pollan, 2018: 240). To put the ensuing effects bluntly, a psychedelic “changes the quality of consciousness more profoundly and yet is less toxic than any other substance in the pharmacologist’s repertory” (Huxley, 2009: 9-10).

From the original binding to the serotonin receptors, psychedelics quickly bring about profound changes in the brain. As Siegel et al. (2024: 131) note, throughout psilocybin’s six-hour long duration, there is a significant increase in the amount of brain connectivity. Essentially, neurotransmitters are triggered to act in ways that present a radically different brain. A 2014 brain scan revealed these notable differences, concluding that psilocybin causes “long-range functional connections that are not present in a normal state” (Petri et al., 2014: 7). As a trend of greater neural connectivity is spurred, other connections between areas in the brain are notably disrupted, especially in the brain’s default mode network (Siegel et al., 2024). Raichle et al. (2001) first discovered the default mode network, or DMN, to be a baseline state of neural behavior that decreases in activity when we engage in specific, goal-directed actions. The DMN can be described in various ways, including as an “orchestra conductor” or “corporate executive” in that it exerts a top-down influence on numerous aspects of neural functioning (Pollan, 2018: 303). In simple, it keeps order within the brain and is responsible for our autobiographical memory and sense of self (Pollan, 2018: 303). Thus, it can be seen how large disruptions of the DMN cause drastic alterations in cognition, shaping the subjective experience in ways that will now be explored.

The subjective effects of psychedelics are manifold. Huxley (2009) describes his experience with mescaline, the psychoactive chemical found in multiple species of cacti, in his *Doors of Perception*. One of the first perceptual changes he experienced was seeing “sumptuous red surfaces swelling and expanding from bright nodes of energy that vibrated with a continuously changing, patterned life” (Huxley, 2009: 16). This identification of inanimate objects pulsating and breathing held a strong importance for Huxley, who described the world before him as one “where everything shone with the Inner Light, and was infinity in its significance” (Huxley, 2009: 22). Again, Huxley is describing a perceptual beauty characterized as infinitely notable, an intuitively strong claim. Likewise, Pollan (2018: 248) explains that listening to music was an incredible part of his LSD experience: “Music had become much greater and more profound than mere sound. Freely trespassing the borders of other senses, it was palpable enough to touch.” For Pollan, sensations became more than mere data originating in bodily organs. His account hints at a feeling of synesthesia, as his sensations were felt in profound, abnormal ways, much like in Huxley’s experience.

Accompanying perceptual changes is a vast shift in thinking that arises from the incredibly abnormal neural activity in a psychedelic experience. For Huxley (2009: 20), this manifested as an indifference to the concepts of time or spatial relations. His mind simply had no concern for such measures; rather, he had a simple zeal for what was in front of him. In perceiving that which was directly available to him, however, “sensum was not immediately and automatically subordinated to the concept” (Huxley, 2009: 25). While we typically can swiftly understand what we sense, deciphering it into clear information, Huxley was merely struck by it, unable to decode the data. Similarly, Pollan (2019: 247), after consuming LSD, found himself “chasing after my mind as it wandered heedlessly through the woods of my life.” Pollan’s introspective experience shows the nonlinear, uncontrollable narrative that psychedelics engender. From the beauty of a flower to a memory from decades ago, the

psychedelic experience begets a drastic shift in cognition that makes the world challenging to decipher.

Perhaps the most drastic of possible effects of psychedelics is the loss of the sense of self, or ego death. Both Huxley and Pollan experienced ego death during their psychedelic experiences. Huxley describes his experience as follows: “In the final stage of egolessness there is an ‘obscure knowledge’ that All is in all—that All is actually each” (Huxley, 2009: 26). Huxley, here, feels fully aware of the state of all things, as the distinction between him and the world has disintegrated. Pollan’s encounter with ego death on psilocybin is perhaps more dramatic, as he says that, “I watched as that familiar self began to fall apart before my eyes, gradually at first and then all at once” (Pollan, 2018: 263). Blindfolded, he saw himself explode into little papers as he witnessed his sense of self dissolve, while feeling increased connectedness with the world (Pollan, 2018: 263). In this way, he faced his own destruction directly and grasped the same knowledge that Huxley found decades prior.

Lebedev et al. (2015: 3146) used brain imaging to show that DMN dysconnectivity, the neural correlate of ego death, is complimented with greater possibility of displeasing, paranoid thoughts and experiences, mimicking psychosis. Pollan and Huxley both avoided any drastic negative thoughts that align with psychosis, but Pollan (2018: 246) does recognize the power of the experience and its vast negative potential by stating that his experience with ego death “should by all rights have been an unmitigating personal disaster.” Both the neuroscience and experiences like Pollan’s underscore that ego death is not just felt as a profoundly enriching feeling; it has a strong negative potential as well.

Psychedelics in Therapy

Psychedelics have a long history of usage in therapeutic settings as a tool for ameliorating the symptoms of a range of mental illnesses, as exemplified by Barber and Aaronson (2022). The causes of these positive changes are far from completely understood, but DMN dysconnectivity

and the shift in the sense of self accompanying it are usually pointed to as the root of such changes. Carhart-Harris et. al (2017) goes further to show that, after a psilocybin experience, there is a subsequent increase in DMN connectivity, higher than usual. This study suggests that this “reset” of the DMN, wherein the ego dissolves and then is put back together in a more robust way, is one cause of the therapeutic benefits of psychedelics. The subjective effects of this reset are analogized by Pollan (2018: 15) as shaking a snow globe:

Habits are undeniably useful tools, relieving us of the need to run a complex mental operation every time we’re confronted with a new task or situation. Yet they also relieve us of the need to stay awake to the world: to attend, feel, think, and then act in a deliberate manner.

Essentially, as the DMN is inactive, felt through ego death during a psychedelic experience, so is a patient’s instincts that he relies on to thrive in a complex world. The ensuing sense of connectedness from ego death is an experience that, as Carhart-Harris et al. (2018) explore, seems to stay with the patient even after the restoration of the DMN, allowing him to better understand his relation to the world. For those with mental illnesses, through this powerful but temporary shift in habits of negative thinking, psychedelics allow for a positive re-evaluation of these thoughts, leading to lasting benefits.

Ultimately, classical psychedelics affect us in many ways. From their ingestion and first binding to serotonin receptors, they rewire our brains and cause radical changes in not only our ability to perceive the world but also our ability to understand it. More than this, though, through their dissolution of the default mode network, our sense of self is altered by psychedelics. This coalesces in the feeling of ego death, or a sustained period where the self-world distinction is no more. While this can be a frightful feeling, it is often viewed as a leading

benefit of psychedelic-assisted therapy that can cause a decrease in symptoms of mental illnesses.

Chapter Three: The Psychedelic Sublime

In this third chapter, I connect the concepts explored in the previous two to assert that the psychedelic experience is a sublime aesthetic. In doing this, I first present two works that make this connection, one of which labels Huxley's psychedelic literature as aesthetically sublime, while the other utilizes Kantian aesthetics to find the experiential roots of the positive effects of psychedelics. Both understandings, I show, fail to adequately develop their connections of psychedelics to the sublime. However, they provide a strong foundation, which I then utilize by further analyzing the connections between psychedelics and Burke and Kant's conceptions of the sublime, respectively. I conclude that Burke's aesthetic framework provides a more complete characterization of the psychedelic experience as a sublime aesthetic. Finally, I briefly examine some implications of this dissertation for the study of both psychedelics and the sublime.

Huxley and a Literary Psychedelic Sublime

In the previous chapter, I mentioned that the term psychedelic came into use through correspondence between Humphrey Osmond and Aldous Huxley. While Osmond's term has dominated mainstream discourse for decades, Huxley's suggestion hints at the intentions of this chapter. Huxley said, "To make this trivial world sublime / take half a gramme of phanerothyme" (Pollan, 2018: 163). This is merely one of many instances in which psychedelics have been characterized as sublime, and this characterization seeks to make sense of the profound changes engendered by psychedelics. Clearly, the powerful effects of psychedelics transcend trite characterizations, like nice or pleasing, necessitating the usage of a term with a stronger gravitas. However, for the psychedelic experience to be considered sublime, the philosophical nuances must be explored, and a specific theory of the sublime must be isolated, due to their great differences.

Firstly, Dickins (2022) examines Huxley's literary aesthetic in *Doors of Perception*, arguing that it is sublime. He begins this exploration by utilizing Burke's differentiation between the sublime and the beautiful, first noting that the profound nature of psychedelics seem to lend themselves to the Burkean beautiful (Dickins, 2022: 72). Just like how Pollan's (2018: 251) LSD experience ended with him embracing platitudes about love, psychedelics seem to hold a distinctly pleasing nature. However, Dickins (2022: 72) swiftly mentions that there is another side to psychedelics, underscored by two occasions where Huxley feels terror in *Doors of Perception*. One of these examples is as follows:

This, I suddenly felt, was going too far. Too far, even though the going was into intenser beauty, deeper significance. The fear, as I analyze it in retrospect, was of being overwhelmed, of disintegrating under a pressure of reality greater than a mind (Huxley, 2009: 55).

This quote recognizes that psychedelic experiences can be frightening. Here, Huxley is overwhelmed by the experience, unable to make sense of it. As his world descends into something he no longer recognizes, the intense beauty is accompanied by a sense of terror caused by such a radically different perspective on the world.

As Dickins (2022: 73) notes, to Huxley, "psychedelic drugs inferred a dual potential, to both enrich and destroy any given individual." He sees Huxley's experience with mescaline as embedded in both wonderful and horrifying emotions, a duality that reflects the combination of awe and terror central to the Burkean sublime (Dickins, 2022: 78). Dickins (2022) centrally cites these moments where Huxley feels terror as evidence of the dual emotional dynamic, leading to his characterization of Huxley's exposition as sublime. This account, however, lacks a critical investigation of whether such a duality strikes the right balance to be considered sublime. It simply notes two emotions as part of both Huxley's work and Burke's, failing to

expand on and evaluate other aspects of the Burkean sublime, like the element of self-preservation. Despite the underdeveloped nature of his argument, Dickins provides a starting point for further examination by identifying these emotional dualities as apt for aesthetic investigation.

Hoffman and the Kantian Sublime

Hoffman (2024) provides one of few accounts that connect psychedelics with the sublime in a philosophical sense, as she uses a Kantian aesthetic framework to understand the positive effects that are engendered by psychedelics. Regarding these positive effects, she says that “[c]urrent evidence indicates that there is something in the psychedelic experience itself that has a causal role” (Hoffman, 2024: 676). This statement highlights that the therapeutic value of psychedelics transcends the neurological understanding presented in the previous chapter, emphasizing the value of the psychedelic experience itself. As such, Hoffman rightly believes that we need to establish a philosophical framework for understanding the experiential aspect of psychedelic transformation.

Hoffman (2024: 679) begins her argument by explaining that an aesthetic framework is useful to dissect the psychedelic experience because such an experience is often described in an aesthetic sense. For example, Pollan (2018: 254) describes his urination, while under the influence of psilocybin, as “truly the most beautiful thing I had ever seen, a waterfall of diamonds cascading into a pool, breaking its surface into a billion clattering fractals of light.” This description is artistic in character, underscoring an increased aesthetic appreciation that is a core part of the psychedelic experience. Thus, an aesthetic understanding of this experience can account for the feelings and moods that prompt such judgements, leading to positive transformation.

Hoffman adopts Kant's aesthetic project and delineates between beautiful and sublime psychedelic experiences. She firstly argues that Kantian beauty is present in purely positive psychedelic experiences, as they both exhibit disinterested pleasure, or finding pleasure in something without the utilization of concepts to understand it (Hoffman, 2024: 684). This recalls the example of a flower's untainted beauty mentioned in the first chapter, and Hoffman (2024: 685) says that such "disinterested pleasure pulls attention away from gratifying our desires and inclinations." In this way, she goes on to say that psychedelic experiences direct one's attention not towards his inner dialogue but instead towards merely observing the world as it is. This is the silencing of mechanisms usually meant to understand the world, like the default mode network, which can be seen when Huxley (2009: 25) states that his sensory perceptions under the influence of mescaline could not be understood according to their relevant concepts. Essentially, he was not able to understand the world through the typical patterns he had developed, instead just simply observing the world from a disinterested point of view. Hoffman (2024: 685) takes this disinterested pleasure, or silencing of mediating influences on the world, to be the root of the positive effects of psychedelic experiences that exhibit Kantian beauty.

Contrasted with the beautiful is the sublime in psychedelic experiences. Hoffman (2024: 685) begins her investigation of the psychedelic sublime by stating that not all psychedelic experiences are pleasant; some are marked by fear and displeasure. She emphasizes that the Kantian sublime, in both its dynamical and mathematical conceptions, represents

a failure to comprehend something that is beyond our capacities, which evokes a negative feeling, followed on by awareness of the way in which we can transcend this limitation through our capacity for reason (Hoffman, 2024: 686).

Whether dynamical or mathematical, Kant's sublime is marked by an element of displeasure. For the dynamical sublime, this displeasure comes from confronting our own vulnerability by meeting a more powerful force (Hoffman, 2024: 686). Hoffman only approaches the element of fear present in the dynamical sublime once, stating that we achieve the dynamical sublime in the psychedelic experience by surrendering to the potential intrinsic in psychedelics, instead of having it amplified (Hoffman, 2024: 686). This is heavily underdeveloped, as surrendering to fear is never further explained, but it seems to represent the Kantian idea that resisting the inciting object of the dynamical sublime is a futile endeavor due to its might. Instead, surrendering to the force of a psychedelic allows for contemplation of their might at a distance. In this understanding, psychedelics, with their potential to induce profound fear, reveal one's vulnerability, exemplifying the dynamical sublime (Hoffman, 2024: 686).

Hoffman then asserts that the mathematical sublime similarly holds strong parallels to the psychedelic experience. She specifies that both the mathematical sublime and psychedelics illicit "cognitions of infinity, boundlessness, or simply the vastness of things in their environment" (Hoffman, 2024: 686). Essentially, psychedelics cause ruminations about infinity, or things vast in scale, through their ability to drastically change one's ability to perceive and think about the world. This mathematical sublime frustrates us, or causes displeasure, by making apparent our imagination's inability to grasp vastness and infinity, though we still can comprehend these concepts when considered by us, even under the influence of psychedelics (Hoffman, 2024: 686). Rationality and reason, then, are key for grasping things of vast and infinite scale, like visions of a boundless world or the infinite nature of the universe. Such reason reinforces our own abilities as rational creatures, making the displeasure hold a pleasing nature, just like in the dynamical sublime.

Ultimately, Hoffman (2024) argues that displeasing psychedelic experiences can be characterized as sublime in a Kantian sense, which she goes on to say is important to the

therapeutic potential of psychedelics. Specifically, she highlights that these “challenging” psychedelic experiences are predictive of positive therapeutic outcomes in psychedelic research, suggesting that there is a positive dimension to overcoming the fear and challenging nature of a psychedelic experience (Hoffman, 2024: 685). It is through this understanding that the Kantian sublime, coupled with the Kantian beautiful, can greatly help us better understand the psychedelic experience.

Hoffman, however, reduces the complexities of psychedelic experiences to a binary distinction: those that are fear-inducing and those that are beautiful. As such, she seemingly understands all psychedelic experiences as having positive, transformative effects by virtue of either being pleasant or by virtue of being fear-inducing. Thus, her account lacks the ability, or, at the very least, further development, to view daunting, purely terrifying psychedelic experiences as anything but “challenging,” or in service of positive transformation. However, Hoffman rightfully highlights that the psychedelic experience is unique and requires a similarly minded characterization, as those who use psychedelics describe such usage in profound ways (Hoffman, 2024: 679). The complexity of the emotions that these experiences engender are better understood through the sublime’s emotional might. This motivation will underscore my attempt to rectify the issues present in both Dickins and Hoffman’s accounts as I determine whether the Burkean or Kantian sublime can better describe the psychedelic experience. In these upcoming sections, my use of the term psychedelic experience will be used to refer only to high-dose experiences. While not specified by Dickins or Hoffman, psychedelics represent a wide range of effects, and restricting my discussion to high-dose experiences is an attempt to best explore the most prominent and potent experiences.

Burke's Sublime and Psychedelic Terror

To reiterate, Burke's (2004: 86) sublime is built on a dual emotional experience, where an element of sublimated terror is presented alongside a feeling of awe. Through this duality, the viewer faces a fight of self-preservation, presenting him with the idea of his own destruction, along with the assurance that such destruction will not come to fruition (Des Pres, 1983: 138-139). The subjective reports of psychedelic experiences in the previous chapter make clear that there is an element of awe intrinsic in this state given that both Huxley and Pollan ascribed incredible significance to their strange perceptions and thinking patterns. It has also already been established that psychedelics can induce terror. Huxley's account demonstrates this and hints at the concept of a "bad trip," which has pervaded psychedelic discourse for decades. Rather than establishing a simple duality as sublime, I will now explore whether the terror of the psychedelic experience strikes the right balance with awe to be described as sublime.

Terror is present in varying forms during psychedelic experiences. One such example follows a participant's interview for a study on adverse psychedelic experiences:

I experienced what it's like to go crazy. It was much worse than torture and death. Because you're stuck in your head, and it's even worse when you know that you're stuck (Gashi, Sandberg and Pederson, 2021: 4).

This quote is representative of a significantly adverse psychedelic experience, where the participant was consumed by terror. Given the belief that this experience was worse than death, the terrifying aspects seem to overshadow any feelings of awe necessary for a sublime aesthetic. For, as Burke (2004: 86) explains, "When danger or pain press too nearly, they are incapable of giving any delight." While the authors of the study go on to show that users of psychedelics tend to later characterize their adverse experiences as valuable and insightful in retrospect (Gashi, Sandberg and Pederson, 2021), the terror is not balanced with any sort of

positive grounding during the experience itself. To put it simply, thoroughly adverse psychedelic experiences are not sublime in a Burkean sense, as the participant in the experience is consumed by a pressing terror that silences any pleasurable emotions.

Returning to Huxley, there is a much subtler experience of terror in his experience on mescaline:

In the intervals between his revelations the mescaline taker is apt to feel that, though in one way everything is supremely as it should be, in another there is something wrong (Huxley, 2009: 41).

This feeling is far different from a pressing, unbearable terror worse than torture. Rather, it is mild terror. The word mild is fitting because, while such terror certainly is felt fear, Huxley is not enveloped by a pressing threat. Instead, he feels terror simply because of the strangeness of the experience. It is the feeling that something is not right, a response to a vastly different neurological state. This strangeness is embodied by an element of mystery, or a failure to ascertain what is to come. Mystery is briefly mentioned by Burke (2004: 102) as an important component of the sublime, and Pollan (2018: 259), as well, feels this mystery-laden mild terror after taking psilocybin: “‘This could easily take a terrifying turn,’ it occurred to me, and with that a dim tide of anxiety began to build.” Here, Pollan expresses the similar feeling that something is not quite right, a fear marked by a lack of awareness of where this experience will lead him. However, this obscured threat is represented by mild terror, not an overwhelming sense of fear.

Psychedelic, mild terror arises from a feeling of strangeness, which itself arises from the vast chemical changes in the mind and the body. These effects of psychedelics are involuntary upon consumption, as shown by the obscured awareness of where the experience would lead the authors of the aforementioned accounts. This is like Burke’s understanding,

which emphasizes the involuntary, forceful nature of the sublime, as opposed to the pleasing nature of the beautiful (Burke, 2004: 108). One involuntary event caused by psychedelics that merits reevaluation is the inhibition of the default mode network and the ensuing experience of ego death. Ego death, to reiterate, is the death of the subjective sense of self. It is an experience that brings about substantial differences in one's recognition of oneself and the world, and it is accompanied with an increased likelihood of unusual sensations and unpleasant experiences. In short, it is not necessarily an enjoyable experience due to the profoundness of its effects. Burke believes that the sublime necessitates a sense of self-preservation, which is emblematic of the strongest of all possible emotions (Burke, 2004: 97). Again, however, the sublime sense of terror is only "delightful when we have an idea of pain and danger, without being actually in such circumstances" (Burke, 2004: 97). This is exactly the trajectory of ego death that was established in the previous chapter. The psychedelic experience, at a high dose, forcibly disintegrates one's sense of self, making existential vulnerability apparent. Though displeasing, the neuroscience is clear that ego death is merely part of a reset of the default mode network, guaranteeing the self's reflexivity, an assurance of psychological safety. Through profound ego death, coupled with an assured sense of the physical safety of psychedelics, the participant of a psychedelic experience safely confronts his own destruction.

In a Burkean sense, the sublime is a subjective feeling in the viewer, not a specific engendering force. Burke (2004: 165) understood that substances like opiates and alcohol could vastly alter our emotions and the way in which we perceive the world, leaving his framework open for a physiologically inclined sublime aesthetic, like with psychedelics. Through the involuntary ways in which psychedelics induce mild terror as a function of strange, novel sensations and thinking patterns, the participant of a psychedelic experience encounters the Burkean sublime. To draw a line as to where such mild terror becomes too overwhelming would be an admittedly difficult task, but the participant's ability to differentiate between

displeasing, or challenging, experiences and thoroughly destabilizing ones should be sufficient for making such a delineation. Overall, while not all psychedelic experiences are sublime, high-dose experiences that are devoid of a pressing, overwhelming fear represent Burke's sublime.

Kant, Fear, and the Psychedelic Infinite

In connecting the psychedelic experience to Kant's understanding of the sublime, like Hoffman, I will evaluate Kant in his two formulations: first, the dynamical sublime, then the mathematical sublime. Much like Burke's sublime, terror plays a strong role in the dynamical sublime, but Kant (2007: 91) says of this terror, "we may look upon an object as fearful, and yet not be afraid of it." As explored in the first chapter, this quote emphasizes that Kant believes there is no terror actually felt in the dynamical sublime, reinforced by his statement that "it is impossible to take delight in terror that is seriously entertained" (Kant, 2007: 91). The terror of the dynamical sublime is, rather, found in the recognition that the object inciting the sublime has the *potential* to incite terror (Kant, 2007: 91). It is this shift of fear away from the viewer that drastically differs from Burke's account.

Under Kant's dynamical sublime, only pleasant, terror-devoid psychedelic experiences can be considered sublime. Though these experiences must display the powerful potential of psychedelics to incite terror, it is still a rather benign experience altogether. This differs from the mild terror explored in the previous section, which, though mild, does represent a true feeling of terror and, as such, is not conducive to the dynamical sublime. The dynamical sublime psychedelic experience almost seems to be one at a lower dose, which can give one a taste of a profound, high-dose experience. However, this chapter is underscored by the idea that it is important to craft a philosophical understanding of the psychedelic experience that speaks to its profound, complex might, instead of a tamed version of its power. Kant's dynamical sublime, while certainly representing a strong emotionality, is unable to capture the

depth of terror and mystery present in the psychedelic experience, which does not merely convey recognition of potential fear but vividly plunges the participant into a feeling of strangeness that begets genuine terror.

Opposing the dynamical sublime, Kant's mathematical sublime seems to highlight a common point of discourse for psychedelic users. This is because the mathematical sublime represents an experience of grand and infinite scale, a common aspect of a psychedelic experience. For example, while blindfolded under the influence of psilocybin, Pollan (2018: 259) describes the video-game dystopia he traversed: "[I]t went on seemingly forever and for hours, with no way out." Psychedelics tend to give their users a taste of the infinite, as they cause a drastic shift in the way in which the world is perceived. Huxley (2009: 26) also exemplifies this idea: "This is as near, I take it, as a finite mind can ever come to 'perceiving everything that is happening everywhere in the universe.'" Here, mescaline offers Huxley a way to expand his understanding of the world beyond typical finite constructions. To Kant (2007: 81), the mathematical sublime is incited by "a greatness comparable to itself alone." Huxley's language is conducive to this definition, as both emphasize something typically inaccessible and profoundly large being felt strongly. To put it in Kantian terms, this ability to comprehend the infinite nature of the universe is simply representative of Huxley's rationality allowing him to understand what he could never simply imagine the scale of.

An important aspect of Kant's sublime is what it shows us about our rationality. As Kant puts it, "we may become conscious of our superiority over nature within, and thus also over nature without us" (Kant, 2007: 94). Essentially, Kant claims that the sublime is a method of making the power of our rationality apparent to us. Through this, we realize the capacity of our minds and such capacity's superiority over the rest of nature (Shaw, 2008: 83). Pollan (2018: 265) shows just this recognition after his experience on psilocybin by saying that "this by itself strikes me as a remarkable gift: that we can let go of so much—the desires, fears, and

defenses of a lifetime!—without suffering complete annihilation.” Such an expression exemplifies exactly what Kant thought was the prime function, or advantage, of the sublime. In taking psychedelics, the strangeness of the experience distorts one’s understanding of his own brain, revealing the previously unexplored potential of the mind. Through Pollan’s thoughts and visions of great magnitude, which would not normally be imaginable, his mind’s power to make sense of his experience was made strongly apparent.

Ultimately, Kant’s dynamical sublime, when applied to profound, high-dose psychedelic experiences, fails to account for the element of terror that is genuinely felt in these experiences. On the other hand, his mathematical sublime is well-equipped to represent the cognitions of grand scale that occur in a psychedelic experience. Ironically, in reducing the ability of the mind through mechanisms like ego death, the rational power of the mind, left intact, reinforces its overarching power. This reflection on the power of the mind is a benefit of the psychedelic sublime and, like Hoffman explores, may highlight the beginning of positive psychedelic transformation.

Assessing the Psychedelic Sublime

In examining both Dickins and Hoffman, it was established that, despite these accounts’ flaws, the sublime provides an appropriately complex philosophical framework for the psychedelic experience. This chapter has been an attempt to further explore how well Burke and Kant’s conceptions of the sublime can serve as this framework. To that effect, Burke’s sublime seems to be a fitting representation of high-dose psychedelic experiences that are not substantially adverse. His theory highlights the feeling of strangeness that creates a mild terror, underscored by the ego eroding in a fight for self-preservation. In accounting for this terror, Burke grasps the emotional duality of psychedelic experiences, all of which combine to create a powerful emotionality that is irreducible to simple explanations. Though Kant provides a telling account

of the power of the sublime in recognizing our mind's abilities, his dynamical sublime can only explain mild, low-dose effects of psychedelics, while his mathematical sublime seems to be restricted to one cognitive effect of psychedelics. The psychedelic experience, however, has been shown to be a rich, complex experience full of powerful, mixed emotions. Ultimately, the powerful complexity of high-dose, non-adverse psychedelic experiences evokes a sublime aesthetic in the Burkean sense, arising from the psychedelic interplay between awe-inspiring feelings, terrifying strangeness, and the fight for self-preservation felt through ego death.

Implications and Further Discussion

Before concluding this dissertation, it is important to address what has been gained through establishing that high-dose, non-adverse psychedelic experiences engender a sublime aesthetic. These gains are twofold, as our knowledge of both psychedelics and the sublime is deepened. Firstly, the psychedelic experience begins to take on new significance. Typically, these drugs find themselves stigmatized, due to decades of prohibition. However, Burke helps to ascribe a sense of aesthetic importance to them. This is because the psychedelic experience is given increased importance under Burke's sublime framework, as it accesses the deepest emotional state possible. Though this profoundness may demonstrate the challenges of consuming psychedelics on a regular basis, this feeling underscores the power of psychedelics in making human emotional potential apparent. Instead of a piece of art or natural formation causing a feeling of the sublime, psychedelics then serve as a chemical expedient to the sublime state.

Just like how Burke adds a philosophical level to the chemical, so does the chemical provide depth to the philosophical. This chemical understanding allows one to induce a sublime aesthetic at will and examine the effects of its prolonged presence. In a psychedelic experience, the sublime state does not merely come and go but overshadows the experience as a whole, marking a sustained state of the sublime. As has been established throughout, psychedelics

have been shown to have a therapeutic value, the mechanism of which arises from challenging emotions and the shifting nature of the ego. Given that these have been labelled as key aspects of the psychedelic sublime, the scientific understanding of the sublime provides fruitful thoughts for further investigation, like if other sublime aesthetics, when sustained, have lasting therapeutic benefits arising from similar neurological states. Such scientific investigation does not diminish the role of philosophy but rather highlights its importance in guiding and complimenting scientific work by crafting important connections, like in this dissertation.

Conclusion

In this dissertation, I have shown that high-dose, non-adverse psychedelic experiences represent a sublime aesthetic in a Burkean sense. I began my argument by exploring the roots of the sublime in 17th-century discourse, before highlighting feelings of awe, sublimated terror, and self-preservation that are key aspects to Burke's sublime. Then, I presented Kant's mathematical sublime, which concerns cognitions of infinity, as well as his dynamical sublime, which is based in a recognition of might. In the second chapter, I restricted my investigation of psychedelics to classical psychedelics, before expounding upon the vast neurological and subjective effects of psychedelics, marked by profound alterations in cognition and perception. These effects culminate in ego death, which I showed is linked to positive therapeutic outcomes. In the final chapter, I showed how prior connections between psychedelics and the sublime have been insufficient, before establishing that the Burkean sublime serves as a strong framework for understanding psychedelic experiences, especially compared to Kant's conception of the sublime. While Kantian sublimity only explains small aspects of the psychedelic experience, the Burkean sublime can speak to the complexity of high-dose, non-adverse psychedelic experiences, which intrinsically evoke awe, mild terror, and feelings of self-preservation. This dissertation serves as an initial step in connecting psychedelics and philosophy. The psychedelic experience is an incredibly complex one necessitating further investigation, but this dissertation has proved the value of aesthetics in understanding these complexities, opening the door for more aesthetic inquiries into the psychedelic experience.

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